

Subject: Articles 19 Tax liens and Article 23 Peepers.

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Dear Town Meeting Moderator Greg Christiana,

Please, disseminate to the Town Meeting members.

Dear Town Meeting Members,

My thoughts on Articles likely in front of you tonight.

Article 19 Tax Liens

[Looks like you passed Article 17](#) turning over municipal and school fee oversight and determination from the legislature (TM) to the executive (department, committees, commissions and boards) essentially to the Town Manager and School Committee.

Interesting that the sister Article 19, tax liens, for some other municipal fees (leaf blowers, off-leash dogs) is probably up for vote tonight. The Selectmen report:

Currently, unpaid noncriminal citations typically require the Town to pursue criminal complaints in District Court, which is costly and time-consuming relative to the dollar

amounts involved (e.g., leaf blower or off-leash dog violations), and with uncertain cost recovery. ... This tool would only apply to violators who own property in Arlington.

How many liens are we talking here? What are the unpaid fee categories (school athletics - again?) and balances?

This is something the Town has tried before. It was a bad idea then, it's a worse idea now. There is a reason judicial friction exists, residents are not the Town's change tray. Liens increase costs when selling a property, another tick up for affordable housing. The school department fees are discretionary and collections not transparent; where are those APS revolving fund balances for Community Ed, building, daycare and after school care anyway? Hopefully, included in the APS budget...

Article 23 Tree Preservation

Vote No here, this is an illegal taking. I have 71 trees or tree-sized bushes on or abutting my property. Many are 40'-70' tall and require about \$5000 in maintenance per year. On average, one comes down every year at great expense. Can anyone on the tree committee report the same?

You want more trees? Give property tax deductions for hosting more trees on your private property. Incentives determine outcomes. Further, stay out of my back yard.

Errata on Privacy

Notice that the [TM Progress Tracker](#) is a google doc that tracks users hosted on the town website but controlled and owned by an elected official. What's up with that? What part of the tracker is a town function and which is official recordings of a public body? Can someone point me to the Town's privacy policy for electronic data collection and outside vendor agreements. Maybe TM should care about the Town's surveillance cameras at the Res, AHS and other places around town.

Privacy used to be a concern, are we past that now?

Stephen Harrington